



Introduction to AI Tools

Step8Up Academy — AI Bootcamp, Session 1

Beginner — any audience

3 hours

Step8Up Academy · AI Bootcamp

What you'll learn today

A hands-on introduction to today's AI toolkit. Learners leave able to describe the main categories of AI, write prompts that get useful results, and assemble a reusable Custom GPT or Claude Project of their own.

1

Describe the main categories of AI tools and when to use each

2

Write prompts using a repeatable framework that gets better, more consistent results

3

Build a Custom GPT or Claude Project that captures a reusable workflow

Today's 3-hour schedule

00:00	Welcome & setup	5 min
00:05	Tuition 1 — Types of AI	15-20 min
00:25	Exercise 1 — Map the AI landscape	20 min
00:45	Tuition 2 — Creating Prompts	15-20 min
01:05	Exercise 2 — Prompt rewrite workshop	20 min
01:25	Short break	10 min
01:35	Tuition 3 — Custom GPTs & Claude Projects	15-20 min
01:55	Exercise 3 — Build your own Custom GPT	20 min
02:15	Recap & Q&A	15-20 min
02:35	Final Challenge — Email marketing campaign generator	25 min

Types of AI

Know your toolkit

B L O C K O B J E C T I V E

By the end of this block you'll be able to place popular AI tools into categories and explain what each category is best at.

1

What we mean by 'AI'

- AI = software that learns patterns from data rather than following hard-coded rules
- Today's boom is driven by generative AI — models that create new text, images, audio, and code
- Two useful framings: narrow AI (does one thing well) vs general AI (not here yet)

The main categories you'll meet

- Large Language Models (LLMs) — text in, text out (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini)
- Image generation — text or image in, image out (Midjourney, DALL·E, Ideogram)
- Audio & voice — speech↔text, voice cloning (Whisper, ElevenLabs)
- Video generation — storyboards, shorts, lip-sync (Runway, Sora, Veo, OpenArt)
- Multimodal models — mix of text, image, audio in one model (GPT-5, Claude, Gemini)

Picking the right tool for the job

- Drafting, summarising, structured output ... LLM
- Concept art, illustration, mood boards ... image generation
- Transcription, dubbing, voiceover... audio
- Explainer videos, B-roll ... video generation
- Agents that take actions (research, fill forms) ... LLM + tools

What AI is NOT

- It isn't a search engine — it can invent facts (hallucination)
- It has a knowledge cut-off — recent events may be wrong or missing
- It doesn't 'understand' — it predicts the next most-likely token
- It reflects its training data — biases in → biases out

EXERCISE 1

20 minutes

Map the AI landscape

THE BRIEF

Pick one real task you or your team does weekly. Identify three different AI tools: one LLM, one image/video/audio tool, and one 'wildcard' of your choice, that could help with part of that task.

For each, note the category, two strengths, one limitation, and a concrete use case that fits your work.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- One real weekly task identified and written down
- Three AI tools chosen, each from a different category
- For each tool: category, two strengths, one limitation, one fit-for-purpose use case
- Ready to share back in one minute per tool

Suggested steps

1. Pick a task you actually do (e.g. weekly newsletter, client reporting)
2. Brainstorm which AI categories could help
3. Pick one LLM tool, one media tool, one wildcard
4. Fill in the four fields per tool
5. Share with a partner and get one question each

Creating Prompts

The input is the product

BLOCK OBJECTIVE

By the end of this block you'll have a reusable framework for writing prompts that consistently produce useful outputs.



Why prompts matter

- Same model, different prompt = wildly different output quality
- A prompt is a brief: the clearer the brief, the better the work
- Prompting is an iterative skill, not a one-shot trick

The R-T-C-F-C framework

- Role — who the model should act as ('You are a senior marketer...')
- Task — what you want it to do ('draft three subject lines...')
- Context — relevant background ('product is a B2B SaaS for accountants...')
- Format — how the output should look (markdown, JSON, table)
- Constraints — rules & guardrails ('under 50 characters, no emojis, UK English')

Prompt patterns worth knowing

- Zero-shot — just ask
- Few-shot — include 2–3 examples of the output you want
- Chain-of-thought — ask it to 'think step by step' for reasoning tasks
- Role-play — assign a persona to shape tone and judgement

Weak vs strong: a rewrite

- Weak: 'write a blog about AI for business'
- Strong: 'You are a B2B content editor. Write a 600-word blog post for non-technical small business owners explaining three practical ways AI can save them admin time this quarter. Tone: warm, no jargon, UK English. Format: H2 section headings + short paragraphs.'
- The difference is role, audience, length, angle, tone, format — all set upfront

EXERCISE 2

20 minutes

Prompt rewrite workshop

THE BRIEF

Take the three weak prompts in your workbook. Rewrite each using the R-T-C-F-C framework. Run the weak and strong versions in ChatGPT or Claude and paste both outputs into your workbook so you can see the difference.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- All three prompts rewritten with every RTCFC element present
- Both outputs (weak + strong) captured side-by-side
- A one-line note per pair: what changed about the output

Suggested steps

1. Read the weak prompt and spot what's missing (role? format? constraint?)
2. Write the strong version — include every RTCFC element
3. Run the weak prompt first, paste the output
4. Run the strong prompt, paste the output
5. Write a one-line 'difference' observation

Prompt 1

- Write a homepage introduction for a roofing company.
- You are a conversion-focused website copywriter. Write a 150-word homepage introduction for a Warwickshire roofing company. Audience: homeowners. Emphasise trust, local expertise and free quotations. UK English. End with a call to action.
- Make it more conversational, reduce jargon and increase the focus on completed projects and customer reviews.

Prompt 2

- Write a marketing email about our new CRM software.
- You are a B2B email marketing specialist.
Write a promotional email announcing a new CRM platform for small businesses.
Context:
Audience: business owners with fewer than 50 employees
Main benefits: automation, customer tracking and reporting
Goal: encourage users to book a demo
Format: Subject line, Preview text, Email body

Constraints:
UK English, Friendly and professional tone, Under 250 words, Include a clear call to action

Prompt 3

- Analyse this spreadsheet.

- You are a business analyst.
Review the attached sales spreadsheet.

Context: Data covers January – June 2026, Business sells IT support services, Management wants to identify growth opportunities

Task: Identify key trends, Highlight the best-performing services, Highlight any areas of concern, Suggest three actions that could improve revenue

Format: Executive Summary, Key Findings, Risks, Recommendations

Constraints:

Use bullet points, Explain findings in plain English, Avoid technical statistical jargon

T U I T I O N . 0 3

Custom GPTs & Claude Projects

From one-off prompts to reusable assistants

B L O C K O B J E C T I V E

By the end of this block you'll understand how to package a workflow into a reusable AI assistant.

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3

What is a Custom GPT / Claude Project?

- A pre-configured AI assistant: system instructions + knowledge files + capabilities
- Solves the 'I keep retyping the same prompt' problem
- Great for recurring workflows, brand tone, specialist knowledge, team-shared tools

The four ingredients

- Name & description — how it shows up in the picker
- System instructions — the standing brief the model follows every time
- Knowledge files — documents it can reference (brand guide, FAQ, price list)
- Capabilities — web browsing, code interpreter, image generation, custom tools

Claude Projects — the equivalent

- Projects bundle a system prompt + reference files + conversation history
- Files stay attached across every conversation in the Project
- Use Projects for a Claude-native version of the same idea

Good practice from day one

- Give it a specific, narrow job — 'do one thing well' beats 'do everything'
- Put examples of ideal output in the system instructions
- Name your versions (v1, v2) as you iterate — don't lose good prompts
- Test edge cases before sharing it with the team

EXERCISE 3

20 minutes

Build your own Custom GPT

THE BRIEF

Build a simple Custom GPT (ChatGPT) or Project (Claude) that answers every question in a chosen style — for example a 'cooking recipe explainer', 'pirate translator', or 'Gen Z marketing reviewer'. You choose the persona; the point is that the behaviour must be consistent without you re-prompting.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Assistant has a name, description, and system instructions
- System instructions include at least one example of ideal output
- Three different test prompts produce outputs consistent with the style
- A one-line description of what you'd change in v2

Suggested steps

1. Open ChatGPT (Explore GPTs → Create) or Claude (New Project)
2. Decide the persona and write a short description
3. Write the system instructions (role, task, tone, constraints, example)
4. Run three different test prompts
5. Note one improvement for v2

Recap — what we covered

Three blocks, three exercises, one skill stack you can use on Monday.

T U I T I O N 1

Types of AI

1. What we mean by 'AI'
2. The main categories you'll meet
3. Picking the right tool for the job

T U I T I O N 2

Creating Prompts

1. Why prompts matter
2. The R-T-C-F-C framework
3. Prompt patterns worth knowing

T U I T I O N 3

Custom GPTs & Claude Projects

1. What is a Custom GPT / Claude Project?
2. The four ingredients
3. Claude Projects — the equivalent

F I N A L C H A L L E N G E

Email marketing campaign generator

A small business client wants an AI assistant that can draft email marketing campaigns on demand. Given a product and an audience, it should return a subject line, preview text, email body, and a clear call-to-action — in their brand tone.

25 minutes · pairs or individual · share back at the end

Challenge — what 'done' looks like

WHAT YOU NEED TO DELIVER

- Pick the right AI tool(s) for the job (and be able to justify the choice)
- Build a Custom GPT or Claude Project that takes product + audience + desired tone as inputs
- Use what you learned about prompting to write the system instructions
- Test it with three different briefs and keep the outputs

STRETCH GOAL

Extend the assistant so it returns three subject-line variations AND can translate the full email into a second language of the team's choice.

This challenge brings together:

1. Types of AI — choosing the right tool for the job

2. Prompting — packaging a repeatable brief into instructions

3. Custom GPTs — turning the prompt into a shareable team tool

That's a wrap.

Take the workbook home. Try the challenge on a real task this week. Bring what you built to the next session.